

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Final Over

Year 5 reading comprehension · Story · 14 marks · About 25 minutes

The sun was sinking behind the Hills hoist, and the backyard cricket match had reached its final over. The scores were level, and the whole family had gathered on the verandah to watch. Mitch gripped the tennis ball so tightly that his fingers ached.

At the other end, his cousin Layla stood with her bat raised and her eyes narrowed like a hawk's. She had been batting for an hour, and nobody had managed to get her out. Last summer, Mitch would have been furious about it. Today, something felt different.

He ran in and bowled. The ball bounced once, twice, and skidded past the old wheelie bin. Layla swung and missed. Mitch's heart leapt. "One more ball like that," he thought, "and the game is mine."

He bowled again. This time, Layla stepped forward and smacked the ball high into the air. It sailed over the fence and landed with a crash in Mrs Kowalski's tomato patch. For a moment, nobody moved. Then Layla's face crumpled. "Oh no," she whispered. "Those were her best tomatoes."

"Over the fence is out," said Mitch. Those were the rules, and everybody knew it. He could have thrown his arms in the air and declared himself the winner. But he looked at the squashed tomatoes, and at Layla's trembling hands, and the words he wanted did not come. "Best game ever," he said instead. "Let's call it a draw."

Layla stared at him. Then, slowly, she grinned. "Come on," said Mitch. "We'll fix the garden. And then we're both apologising."

Mrs Kowalski, it turned out, was not angry at all. She laughed so hard that she had to lean on her fence, and then she handed them a bag of tomatoes. "Next time," she said, her eyes twinkling, "aim for the neighbours who don't grow tomatoes."

1. What was the score at the start of the final over? (1 mark)

2. The text says Mitch "would have been furious." What does "furious" mean? (1 mark)

3. The writer says Layla's eyes were "narrowed like a hawk's." What does this comparison suggest about how she was batting? (2 marks)

4. The writer says, "Last summer, Mitch would have been furious about it. Today, something felt different." What do you think had changed for Mitch? Use evidence from the story. (2 marks)

5. Quote the sentence that shows Mitch had a chance to claim victory. Use quotation marks. (2 marks)

6. Why did Mitch call the game a draw? Use evidence from the story. (2 marks)

7. Do you think Mitch made a good decision? Explain your view, using the story. (2 marks)

8. Write a summary of the story in two sentences. Include what happened and how Mitch changed. (2 marks)

Writing task: Write the next scene: Mitch and Layla knock on Mrs Kowalski's door. What happens?
